

“ READ MY LIPS: NO NEW TAXES. ”

George Bush, accepting the Republican presidential nomination in New Orleans, August 18, 1988

THREE MEMBERS OF THE IRISH REPUBLICAN ARMY (IRA) were shot dead by the Secret Air Service (SAS) in Gibraltar, on 6 March. The IRA was planning to **detonate a bomb** during a “change of guard” ceremony in the British territory. The event was to be attended by the 1st Battalion Royal Anglian Regiment, following a tour of Northern Ireland. The incident led to a **wave of violence** in Belfast.

This year saw the first documented use of **chemical weapons** in the Iran–Iraq war, when Iraq dropped bombs containing **mustard gas and nerve agents** on the Kurdish city of **Halabja** in Iraq, in March. Between 3,000 and 5,000 civilians died, and many more suffered long-term health problems. The massacre is known as “**Bloody Friday**” (see 2010).

On 8 August, a UN-arranged **ceasefire** ended the **Iran–Iraq war** (see 1980). Lasting eight years, the war resulted in more than **1 million casualties**.

Throughout 1988, Palestinian Arabs of the **Gaza Strip** and **West Bank** continued a mass uprising against Israeli occupation of Palestinian territories. Known as “**intifada**”, it took the form of general strikes, boycott of Israeli products, demonstrations, and use of **petrol bombs**. On 14 November, the Palestine

Horsehead nebula

The resumption of shuttle flights, in 1988, meant that NASA's Hubble Space Telescope programme was back on track. Hubble would produce stunning images of the universe.

Liberation Organization (PLO) accepted the “**two-state solution**” (see 1947), officially recognizing Israel's right to exist.

On 2 December, **Benazir Bhutto** (see panel, below) was sworn in as **Pakistan's first female prime minister**. At 35, she also became the youngest leader of a world nation (see 2007).

Mikhail Gorbachev's **perestroika** (economic and political reforms), and **glasnost** (open debate), played a key role in ending the Cold War (see 1948). In a dramatic speech to the UN, on 7 December, Gorbachev announced unilateral **arms and troop reductions**, and withdrawal of forces from Eastern Europe.

On 21 December, **Pan Am flight 103** crashed at **Lockerbie**, Scotland, killing all 259 passengers and crew, and 11 on the ground. Evidence of a **bomb** instigated a huge investigation. Two **Libyan intelligence agents** were linked to the bombing, although it took over 11 years to bring them to trial.

George Bush (b.1924) became the first US vice president since 1836 to win the **presidential election**. On 8 November, he claimed a comfortable victory over democrat **Michael Dukakis**.

South Africa's border war with Namibia and Angola had been ongoing since 1966. South Africa was under intense pressure from the international community to **grant Namibia independence**. They agreed to do this, but only if **Cuba** removed its troops from **Angola**. Initially the UN rejected this proposal, but on 22 December the participants met in New York where a **bilateral agreement** was signed by Cuba and Angola, and a **tripartite accord**, by Angola, Cuba, and South Africa.

In April, Stephen Hawking (b.1942) published **A Brief History of Time**, a story of the Universe from the “**Big Bang**”. The most popular science book ever, it was translated into 40 languages and sold more than **10 million copies**.

BENAZIR BHUTTO (1953–2007)

Benazir Bhutto set up the Pakistan People's Party (PPP) in London after her father, Zulfikar Ali Bhutto, was assassinated in 1979. She returned to Pakistan in 1986 and served as prime minister from 1988–90 and 1993–96. Benazir was exiled in 1999 on corruption charges, but returned in 2007 for fresh elections. Two months later, she was assassinated in a suicide attack.



- May 10 Francois Mitterrand reelected French president
- May 11 Death of Kim Philby, Soviet spy
- May 31 US president Ronald Reagan makes first trip to Moscow
- August 8 Ceasefire in Iran–Iraq War
- August 350 UN observers monitor Iraq–Iran ceasefire
- August–September Massive floods overwhelm two-thirds of Bangladesh
- September 30 Ben Johnson stripped of gold medal at Seoul Olympics
- October 1 Mikhail Gorbachev elected president of USSR
- October 8 George Bush elected US president
- October 13 Turin Shroud declared a fake after carbon dating tests
- November 9 US Air Force reveals stealth bomber aircraft
- November 16 Estonia demands independence from Soviet rule
- November 19 Serbia holds mass rally for independence
- December 2 Benazir Bhutto sworn in as prime minister of Pakistan
- December 7 Huge loss of lives in Armenian earthquake
- December 12 Clapham Rail disaster in Britain; 35 killed
- December 14 US declares willingness to open dialogue with PLO
- December 21 Lockerbie bombing: Pan Am Flight 103 explodes over town; 270 killed
- December 22 South Africa signs tripartite agreement with Angola and Cuba
- December 24 US Anglicans elect first woman bishop
- December 29 US space program back on track with launch of space shuttle Discovery
- December 31 India and Pakistan sign pledge to refrain from attacking each other's nuclear establishments